

Sunny and Cocoa at Cottonwood Bend

Cowboy story • 3-4 years old



Sunny rode her little brown horse, Cocoa, across the wide, wide land. The sky was big and blue. The grass waved like a green sea.

Sunny was a young cowgirl. She wore a soft hat and a red scarf. She held the reins with gentle hands.

“Easy, Cocoa,” she said.

Cocoa made a quiet snort. Clip-clop, clip-clop.

Sunny had a brave plan. She wanted to find a good place to stay. A home place. A welcome land with water, shade, and room to grow.

In her saddle bag she had a small tin cup, a biscuit, and a folded map. The map was old and crinkly. It showed a star by a spot called Cottonwood Bend.

Sunny looked at the map. Then she looked at the sun.

“West,” she whispered. “We go west.”

The wind puffed warm and friendly. It pushed her scarf like a little flag.

Soon the trail turned sandy. The wheels of an old wagon had left deep lines. Sunny followed them.

Then—clack!

Cocoa stepped on a loose stone. The stone rolled. Cocoa’s hoof slipped.

“Oh!” Sunny said.

She leaned low and hugged Cocoa’s neck. She stayed calm. Cocoa found his balance again.

“You did it,” Sunny said softly. “Good horse.”

Cocoa's ears tipped back, listening. Then forward again. Clip-clop, clip-clop.

They came to a shallow creek. The water shined like a ribbon. Little frogs sat on round rocks.

Sunny smiled. "A drink for you, Cocoa. And a drink for me."

Cocoa lowered his head and drank. Sunny filled her tin cup and took small sips.

The creek was not deep, but the stones were slippery. Sunny watched the water. She thought hard.

"Slow steps," she told Cocoa. "One, two. One, two."

Cocoa stepped carefully. Sunny kept her body steady. They crossed safe and sound.

On the other side, Sunny saw a fence. The fence was crooked. One post leaned like a tired old man.

A sign hung on one nail. It said, in wobbly letters: PLEASE CLOSE THE GATE.

The gate was open.

Sunny frowned. "Oh no. If it stays open, animals may wander."

She rode closer. Inside the fence, a few fluffy sheep munched grass. Farther away, a ranch house sat low and warm in the sun.

Sunny could have ridden past fast. She could have said, "Not my problem."

But Sunny was humble. She did not think, I am too busy to help. She thought, We all need help sometimes.

She got down from Cocoa. Her boots made soft thuds in the dust.

“Stay,” she told Cocoa.

Cocoa stayed.

Sunny walked to the gate and pushed it. It was heavy. The wood creaked.

She pushed again. “Hnn.”

It moved a little. Then it stuck.

Sunny blinked. “Okay. New plan.”

She looked at the ground. A small stone was wedged under the gate.

Sunny knelt. She used both hands. She wiggled the stone. It would not move.

She took a slow breath. “I can try again.”

She found a short stick by the fence. She slid it under the stone like a tiny lever.

“Lift,” Sunny whispered.

Pop!

The stone jumped free. The gate swung closed with a happy thunk.

Sunny tied the latch. “There. Safe.”

A voice called from the porch. “Well now! Thank you, miss!”

A kind rancher lady waved. Her hair was silver. Her smile was bright.

Sunny lifted her hat. “You’re welcome. I just saw the gate open.”

The rancher lady walked over. She moved slow, but strong.

"I'm Mrs. Juniper," she said. "And you are?"

"Sunny," Sunny said. "This is Cocoa."

Cocoa gave a polite snort.

Mrs. Juniper chuckled. "Good manners. Come have a biscuit. You must be travel-worn."

Sunny's cheeks warmed. "Thank you. But I only need a little."

Inside the yard, Mrs. Juniper poured water into a bowl for Cocoa. Then she handed Sunny a biscuit and a peach.

Sunny held the peach like a treasure. "I can share," she said.

Mrs. Juniper nodded. "That's a fine way to be."

Sunny took a small bite. Sweet juice ran down her thumb. She licked it and giggled.

Then a boy ran up from behind the house. He was about Sunny's size. He carried a bucket.

"A sheep got out," he said, out of breath. "But the gate is closed now!"

Mrs. Juniper patted his shoulder. "Because Sunny helped."

The boy's eyes got wide. "Wow."

Sunny shook her head gently. "It wasn't hard. I just tried and tried."

The boy smiled. "I'm Pip."

"Hi, Pip," Sunny said. "Do you know Cottonwood Bend?"

Pip pointed past the hills. "That way. There's a bend in the river. Big trees. Cool shade."

Sunny's heart did a happy thump. "That's where my map star is."

Mrs. Juniper looked at Sunny's boots and the dusty trail. "Are you looking for a home place?"

Sunny nodded. "Yes, ma'am. A welcome land."

Mrs. Juniper's eyes were soft. "Then rest a bit first. A brave rider knows when to pause."

Sunny liked that. She did not need to prove she was tough all the time. She could be wise, too.

They sat under the porch shade. A gentle breeze fluttered Sunny's scarf. Cocoa munched hay.

After a short rest, Sunny stood. "Thank you for the water and the peach."

Mrs. Juniper handed her a small cloth bag. "For the trail. Just a few oats and two biscuits."

Sunny's eyes widened. "That's a lot."

Mrs. Juniper smiled. "Not too much. And someday you will help another traveler. That's the way of the West."

Sunny held the bag close. "I will. I promise."

Pip waved both hands. "Good luck, Sunny!"

Sunny swung up onto Cocoa. She sat tall, but not proud. Just steady.

“Ready, Cocoa?” she asked.

Cocoa stepped forward. Clip-clop, clip-clop.

The land opened wide again. Golden grass. Blue sky. Far hills like sleepy giants.

The trail grew rocky, then smooth, then sandy again. Sunny kept her eyes sharp. She counted Cocoa’s steps when the ground looked tricky.

“One, two. One, two,” she whispered.

At last, the air turned cool. She heard water before she saw it.

Then she did see it—river water shining and moving, and tall cottonwood trees with leaves that clapped softly in the wind.

Sunny rode to the bend. She slid down and touched the tree bark.

“Hello,” she said to the place, like it was a friend.

Cocoa drank. Birds chirped. The world felt calm and kind.

Sunny looked up at the cottonwoods. “This could be our welcome land,” she said.

She set a small blanket on the grass. She ate one biscuit and saved one.

The sun began to sink. The sky turned pink, then orange, then sleepy purple.

Sunny leaned against Cocoa’s warm side. “We were brave today,” she said. “And we were careful. And we were humble.”

Cocoa breathed slow and steady.

The river sang a soft song. The cottonwood leaves whispered back.

Sunny closed her eyes. She felt safe. She felt thankful.

And in the wide, gentle West, Sunny and Cocoa rested at Cottonwood Bend, ready for tomorrow's bright ride.

The quiz: did you understand the story well?

1) What is the girl's name?

- Sunny
- Lily
- Anna
- Mia

2) What animal is with Sunny?

- Horse named Cocoa
- Dog named Spot
- Cat named Whiskers
- Cow named Bella

3) Where did Sunny rest at the end?

- Cottonwood Bend
- Big Mountain
- Sunny Farm
- Red Barn

4) What did Sunny do to help at the gate?

- She closed the gate
- She opened a box
- She fed the chickens
- She painted the fence

Correct answers:

1) Sunny 2) Horse named Cocoa 3) Cottonwood Bend 4) She closed the gate

Glossary: complicated words in the story

Saddle bag: A bag that hangs from the seat on a horse to carry small things.

Crinkly: Makes small, dry, crunchy sounds when you touch it.

Reins: Long straps the rider holds to guide the horse.

Clip-clop, clip-clop.: The sound of a horse's hooves as it walks.

Creek: A small stream of water that runs through the land.

Slippery: Hard to stand on because it is smooth and you can slide.

Wedged: Stuck tightly in a small space so it will not move.

Lever: A stick or bar used to push or lift something heavy.

Latch: A small bar that keeps a gate or door closed.

Travel-worn: Tired and a little messy after a long trip.

Humble: Being kind and not showing off or bragging.

Porch: A small roofed area by the front of a house to sit.